

A SPECIAL EDITION OF

MERIDIAN

The Hermès Birkin — an ultra deep dive



An Hermès Birkin in ostrich leather — the exotic-skin end of the range this book prices, argues over and, in one case, watches sell for more than most houses. Source: Wikimedia Commons.

THE FLIGHT

The date Jane Birkin herself couldn't keep straight across three decades of retelling, and the co-founder whose own side of the story was never once put on the record

THE MARKET

A ten-minute bidding war, a €7 million hammer, and a resale premium that has quietly halved since 2022 — two truths about the same bag, both real, both in this book

THE UNDERCURRENT

Tokyo's Ginza is where a decades-old bubble-economy stockpile of Birkins keeps meeting the weak yen — and a \$10 million auction just handed the district its best year yet

THIS SPECIAL EDITION

The Birkin, Argued at Collector Level — Companion to No. 75.5's Kelly, Built Not to Repeat It

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FROM THE DESK

"I said, 'the day Hermès makes one with pockets I will have that.' And he said: 'but I am Hermès, and I will put pockets in for you.'"

— Jane Birkin, recounting the 1980s flight, to *Vogue*, March 2012¹

That exchange is the one primary quote this book could pin to Jane Birkin's own mouth. Almost everything usually surrounding it — the year, the route, what exactly spilled — moves depending on which decade she was asked (p3). This book follows the bag from that uncertain beginning through a design argument with its own sibling (p5), a market that can't agree with itself (p10), and a Tokyo district living off the gap between what Japan bought in the 1980s and what the world wants back today (p21). Companion to No. 75.5's Kelly — the house history and leather school already ran there; this one earns its own pages on what's distinct to the Birkin.

THE STRIP — THE BAG, AT A GLANCE

MEASURE	READING
Standard sizes	25 / 30 / 35 / 40 cm
Launch year	1984 (flight itself: disputed)
Construction styles	Retourné (1984–) & Sellier (2014–)
Jane Birkin prototype, Sotheby's Paris	€8.6m total, Jul 2025
Resale premium over retail	2.2× (2022) → 1.4× (Nov 2025)
Antitrust suit (Cavalleri v. Hermès)	Dismissed w/ prejudice, on appeal
Hermès Leather Goods & Saddlery, FY2025	>€7bn, 44% of group
r/TheHermesGame, Reddit	~73,000 members
Hours per bag, per Axel Dumas	15–16, house won't compress it

Figures sourced and hedged throughout; see per-page footnotes. Hermès does not publish an official production-hours, quota or unit-volume figure for the Birkin.²

SOURCES 1. Jane Birkin, interviewed by Luke Leitch, *Vogue*, March 2012, at the Hermès Fall 2012 show. 2. See p8–9 on production hours and capacity, and p10–12 on resale and auction data.

THE FLIGHT • ORIGINS

A Sick Bag, a Spilled Basket, and a Date Even Jane Birkin Couldn't Hold Steady

The skeleton of the story is real and well corroborated. Almost every detail hanging off it — the year, the route, what exactly spilled — turns out to depend on which decade you ask.

The skeleton survives every version this book checked: Jane Birkin, on a flight seated beside Jean-Louis Dumas — then Hermès's chairman and chief executive, a title he had held since 1978, not the "artistic director" tag some retellings borrow from his son Pierre-Alexis, who took that role only in 2005 — spilled the contents of a woven basket she used as a handbag; a conversation followed about the lack of a practical Hermès bag for a young mother; she sketched a design, by her own account on an airline sick bag; Dumas had it built and asked to name it after her.¹ That recurs, primary and secondary, everywhere this book looked.

The date does not survive scrutiny, including from Birkin herself. Her March 2012 *Vogue* interview places the flight in 1981; Smithsonian Magazine's account, also drawing on her retellings, gives 1983; most general press simply says "1984" — reliably the year the finished bag reached market. The likeliest explanation: decades of retelling collapsed "the flight happened" and "the bag launched" into one year. This book states what it can verify — the encounter predates the 1984 launch by an unknown, possibly short interval, not a fixed date.² The route is more consistent — most tellings, including Birkin's own, put it Paris to London — though a minority of retailer copy reverses the direction, drift through repetition rather than an independent claim.

"On this airplane journey, when everything fell out of whatever bag I had, the man next to me said, 'you should have one with pockets.' I said, 'the day Hermès makes one with pockets I will have that.' And he said: 'but I am Hermès, and I will put pockets in for you.'" — Jane Birkin, to *Vogue*, March 2012

Even the basket's backstory splits: one strand has Birkin buying it in the Algarve in the 1970s; another has her finding it at a London market. Smithsonian's account adds a detail nowhere else — that her daughter Charlotte was on the flight too. And the sketching moment has a second primary telling, from a CNN interview with Christiane Amanpour aired February 2020: "He said, 'Well, draw it for me,' and so I drew it on one of those sick bags — the vomit bags — in the airplane."³ Reported consistently across outlets, though this book could not itself pull the original broadcast to confirm the transcript word for word.

IN BRIEF — WHAT HOLDS AND WHAT DOESN'T

Holds: the spilled basket, the sketch on a sick bag, Dumas naming the bag after her.

Doesn't: a single agreed year for the flight itself, a fixed account of what the basket was or where it came from.

THE RECORD

What's genuinely striking, checked across every source this book reached, is what's missing rather than what's disputed: no dated, on-the-record account from Jean-Louis Dumas himself has ever surfaced. Every version of "his side" comes filtered through Birkin's retellings, company lore or press paraphrase. He died in 2010. If he ever told this story in his own words for the record, this book could not find it — and treats that absence as a finding, not an oversight.

THE SCEPTIC

A founding myth this well-worn, repeated this identically for forty years, usually means either it's simply true and stable, or nobody with a commercial interest in the bag had a reason to correct it. This book can't fully distinguish the two — only flag that the version everyone repeats is Birkin's own shifting one, never independently corroborated against an itinerary, a boarding pass or Dumas's own account.

SOURCES 1. Convergent across *Vogue* (Mar 2012), Euronews (18 Jul 2023), Hermès's own brand copy, and general fashion-history secondary sourcing; Jean-Louis Dumas's chairman/CEO tenure (1978–2006) and Pierre-Alexis Dumas's artistic-director role (from 2005) cross-checked against multiple obituary and company-history sources. 2. Jane Birkin, *Vogue*, Mar 2012 (states 1981); Smithsonian Magazine (states 1983, via Birkin's own account); *TIME* and most general press (state 1984, the bag's market year) — genuinely unresolved; treated here as an open question, not a printable fact. 3. Jane Birkin, CNN interview with Christiane Amanpour, aired 21 Feb 2020, as reported across secondary coverage; original broadcast transcript not independently re-pulled for this book.

THE FLIGHT · CONTINUED

She Asked Hermès to Take Her Name Off the Bag. It Never Happened — and Nobody Ever Quite Said No

The 2015 crocodile episode is the best-documented chapter of Birkin's own relationship with the bag. It is also the one where the record shows her explicit request was never actually granted.

In late June 2015, PETA released undercover footage from Lone Star Alligator Farms in Winnie, Texas — reportedly half-owned by a Zimbabwe-based crocodile-farming supplier with Hermès-linked tannery ties — showing animals improperly stunned before slaughter.¹ On 29 July, via AFP, Birkin issued a statement republished near-identically across at least five independent outlets, a corroboration level unusual for a wire quote: "Having been alerted to the cruel practices reserved for crocodiles during their slaughter to make Hermès handbags carrying my name... I have asked Hermès to debaptise the Birkin Croco until better practices in line with international norms can be put in place."² Hermès said it shared her concerns and would investigate; an internal audit reportedly found an "isolated irregularity." By September the two sides had, in press shorthand, "made up" — Hermès stating Birkin had told them she was satisfied by the measures taken.

What most retellings skip: the crocodile Birkin was never actually renamed. Her written request — "debaptise" — was not granted; the substantive ask disappears once "resolved" gets printed. No Hermès quote explicitly declining the request exists either; the absence of any renaming, sustained a decade on, is the evidence, not a direct refusal on record.³

2015

THE REQUEST; STILL, IN 2026, "BIRKIN CROCO" ON THE PRICE LIST

Jane Birkin died 16 July 2023, at 76, at her Paris home; no official cause was released, though she had a documented history of stroke and leukaemia treatment — facts not to be conflated into a cause. Nearly every obituary led with the bag; a rarer counter-note, CNN Opinion, ran a piece the same week arguing it "undermines Jane Birkin's true legacy," and Euronews's own obituary-week headline — "A happy accident? The story behind the Birkin Bag" — carried its own question mark.⁴ One resale-

platform founder, quoted in the South China Morning Post, said plainly: "the sad death of Jane Birkin does have an impact on the value of the handbags" — a genuine, attributed quote, but a single, commercially interested source, printed here as exactly that rather than as market data. This book found no rigorous, isolated dataset quantifying a "Jane Birkin effect" on ordinary resale prices distinct from the broader market moves detailed on [p10](#).

One lineage claim deserves the same scepticism this book applies throughout: that the Birkin was "directly modelled on" the Hermès Haut à Courroies, the house's circa-1892 saddle-carrier bag. The claim's earliest traceable appearance in mainstream press is a 2007 TIME piece; since then it has become fixed largely through auction-house marketing — Sotheby's runs content literally titled "The Original Birkin Bag" about the HAC, a direct commercial interest since it is what makes vintage HAC bags marketable to Birkin collectors. The resemblance is visually real. That Dumas consciously drew on it is, on this book's research, narrative built by press and salerooms — not a confirmed fact from Hermès's own design history.⁵

COMMUNITY READ

Birkin's own daughter Charlotte Gainsbourg made a 2021 documentary about her mother, *Jane by Charlotte* — reviewers describe it as not dwelling on the bag-origin story at all. For a book doing myth-versus-fact, that's a genuinely useful negative finding: the most intimate on-camera portrait made by her own child apparently doesn't retell the flight anecdote either.

THE SCEPTIC

"Resolved" is doing a lot of work in the 2015 story's standard telling. A request that is acknowledged, investigated and then quietly not acted upon is not the same as a request that succeeds — and a bag brand's public "we've made up" statement is not independent confirmation that the underlying practice actually changed to Birkin's satisfaction, only that she said so.

SOURCES 1. PETA undercover investigation, Lone Star Alligator Farms, Winnie, Texas, footage released ~24–27 Jun 2015; cross-corroborated by Their Turn, FashionUnited, CBS News. 2. Jane Birkin statement via AFP, 29 Jul 2015, republished by CNBC, Forbes, Billboard and NPR/Hawaii Public Radio with matching wording. 3. Absence of any subsequent Hermès renaming of the crocodile Birkin, sustained across all sourcing reached for this book; no direct Hermès refusal quote found. 4. CNN Opinion (Sheppard), 20 Jul 2023; Euronews, 18 Jul 2023; South China Morning Post, quoting Hanushka Toni, founder of resale platform Sellier — single-sourced observation, flagged as such. 5. TIME, 17 Apr 2007 (earliest traced instance); Sotheby's editorial content on the Haut à Courroies; no Hermès company-archive statement confirming the design lineage was found.

THE ARGUMENT · DESIGN

No Strap, Two Rolled Handles, and a Flap That's Allowed to Just Hang Open

The companion Kelly book covered the house history and the leather school. This is the part that's actually distinct: two bags sharing an ancestor, built to be used in opposite ways.

Strip away the shared Hermès DNA and the mechanical difference is stark. The Birkin's front flap carries two finished slits that let the handles pass through and stand upright — the flap can be thrown open or closed, and the bag functions as a handheld tote whether it's latched or not. The Kelly's flap fully covers the opening, secured by a turn-lock plus two sangle straps, and by collector-guide consensus "must always be carried securely closed."¹ That's not a stylistic quirk. It changes what each bag is actually for: one is built to be plunged into and out of all day; the other is built to stay shut until you deliberately open it.

The handles carry the same logic further. The Birkin has two rolled leather top handles and, in its standard form, no strap at all — carried by hand or in the crook of the arm, full stop. Each handle is hand-rolled from several layers of leather, a process one collector guide puts at "up to four hours" per handle; this book could not independently corroborate that specific figure beyond the one source and flags it as such. The Kelly, by contrast, ships with a detachable, matching shoulder strap — three carry modes against the Birkin's one.² Multiple retailer and collector guides converge on this as the single clearest functional advantage the Kelly holds: crossbody carry, hands genuinely free, something the standard Birkin structurally cannot do.

One bag is built to be plunged into all day. The other is built to stay shut until you decide otherwise. That is the entire argument, and everything else — resale, taxonomy, the community's decade-long debate — sits on top of it.

There is one real, current exception worth flagging precisely because it complicates the "no strap" rule: Hermès has revived the "Shoulder Birkin" — an East-West, slouchier silhouette explicitly framed by dealer press as reviving Jean Paul Gaultier's early-2000s take for the house, expanded through 2024 and 2025, with a 29cm version shown on the Spring/Summer 2025 runway. It remains a niche variant, not the standard bag, but a collector-level book should say so rather than let "the Birkin has no strap" stand as an absolute.³

COMMUNITY READ

PurseForum's practicality threads on this exact question — titles include "Birkin vs. Kelly — in a practical sense," "BIRKIN or KELLY?" and "first hermès — kelly or birkin?" — run for pages without fully resolving. The pattern this book found, reading around rather than into the threads directly: Birkin partisans cite ease of access; Kelly partisans cite the strap and a dressier, more "put-together" presentation. Consensus reads as lifestyle-dependent rather than settled either way.

Trade press treats the question as live enough to keep writing about: PurseBlog's own analysis, "Is Your Hermès Birkin or Kelly Truly an Investment?", exists specifically because the two bags' collector reputations diverge in ways a simple "both are Hermès" framing misses — the Birkin's reputation rests on liquidity and immediate recognisability, the Kelly's on restraint and a steeper practicality cost that, on this book's own research (p6), may be exactly what makes exotic Kellys age less gracefully into resale than exotic Birkins.⁴ Neither reputation is fixed by Hermès itself — both are built collector generation by collector generation, in exactly the threads named above.

SOURCES 1. Convergent across Madison Avenue Couture, Xupes and JaneFinds Birkin-vs-Kelly comparison guides. 2. Handle-rolling time: single collector-guide source, flagged as unverified beyond that one citation; shoulder-strap carry-mode comparison convergent across multiple retailer guides. 3. PurseBop, "The Shoulder Birkin Light Is Hermès' Best Throwback Yet"; Privé Porter and Jewels Aficionado coverage of the 2024–2025 Shoulder Birkin revival and its SS2025 runway appearance. 4. PurseBlog, "Is Your Hermès Birkin or Kelly Truly an Investment?"; associated PurseForum thread (forum.purseblog.com/threads/1015047), not independently re-read.

THE ARGUMENT • THE VALUE QUESTION

Exotic Kellys Show Wear at the Corners. Exotic Birkins, Collector Guides Argue, Don't — as Visibly

A construction detail with a real resale consequence: the same softness that makes the Birkin easier to live with may also be what lets it age less visibly in exotic skins.

One structural claim genuinely distinguishes the Birkin-versus-Kelly value debate from a simple style preference: dealer commentary — specifically flagged here as a single-sourced claim from one collector-guide operator, not an auction house — suggests exotic Kellys, especially in Sellier construction, are "arguably rarer in pristine condition because the structured form shows wear at corners more visibly than the Birkin's rounded, Retourné profile." If broadly true, that would mean the Birkin's softer, unstructured shape isn't just a carrying-style choice — it may be part of why it ages into resale better in exotic skins specifically. This book could not corroborate the claim against a second source and prints it as one dealer's observation, not settled fact.¹

The investment framing predates this book by a decade and traces almost entirely to one 2016 study: Baghunter, an online reseller of pre-owned Hermès bags, compared 1980–2015 Birkin values against the S&P 500 and gold, and reported Birkins appreciating at an average 14.2% a year against the S&P's roughly 8.7% and gold's actual decline over the same window — a headline repeated by Time, Refinery29 and The Fashion Law largely unchallenged.² The conflict of interest is not subtle: Baghunter sells the exact product its own study concludes is a great investment. This book could not locate a named, dated methodological takedown of the study specifically — only generic "reseller, possible conflict" observations — which is itself worth stating plainly: the single most-repeated "Birkins beat gold" claim in circulation has never, as far as this book's research could establish, been rigorously fact-checked by an independent financial journalist. See [p10](#) for what more recent, less commercially-interested data actually shows.

14.2%

BAGHUNTER'S CLAIMED ANNUAL BIRKIN RETURN, 1980–2015
— STUDY BY A BIRKIN RESELLER

The record sale that keeps getting cited on both sides of this argument belongs to neither camp cleanly: Jane Birkin's own original 1984 prototype — not a production bag, sticker-covered and personally modified by her over a decade of daily use — sold at Sotheby's Paris in July 2025 for €8.6 million all-in, the highest price ever paid for a handbag at auction (full detail on [p10](#)). It is cited constantly as proof the object "holds value." It is, on the evidence, proof that a unique piece of personal fashion history holds value — a genuinely different claim from "a standard Birkin 30 in Togo appreciates reliably," which the resale data on this book's own market pages does not straightforwardly support.

Hardware choice carries its own, imprecisely documented, price signal. One breakdown — a handbag-market newsletter called Bagworld, printed here with that single-source caveat rather than as market data — claims gold hardware accounts for just over 40% of the Hermès auction market against palladium's 52%, yet gold has "reliably averaged more than palladium" at auction, attributed to relative rarity. Dealer-guide price ranges for Birkin exotics run above their Kelly equivalents: a Birkin 25 exotic quoted around \$45,000–75,000 against a Kelly 25 exotic's \$40,000–60,000, matte alligator Birkin 25s reaching \$80,000–120,000, lisse finish adding a further 10–15% over matte — dealer-guide compilations, not auction-house transaction records.³⁴

THE SCEPTIC

"Better than gold" is doing enormous work for a claim that traces to one interested party's decade-old study, repeated by outlet after outlet without a second look. This book isn't asserting the opposite — only that a claim this load-bearing for how people justify a five-figure purchase deserves more scrutiny than it has evidently ever received.

SOURCES 1. Single collector-guide source (GinzaXiaoma-style dealer commentary); not independently corroborated, printed as a flagged single-source claim. 2. Baghunter study, published 8 Jan 2016, updated 2017; coverage via Time (2016), The Fashion Law, CNBC (22 Mar 2025); no independent methodological critique of the study itself located in this book's research. 3. Bagworld (Substack newsletter) hardware market-share and price commentary; single-sourced, not institutional auction-house data. 4. Aggregated dealer-guide pricing (GinzaXiaoma, JaneFinds, Collector's Cage); illustrative only, not verified transaction data.

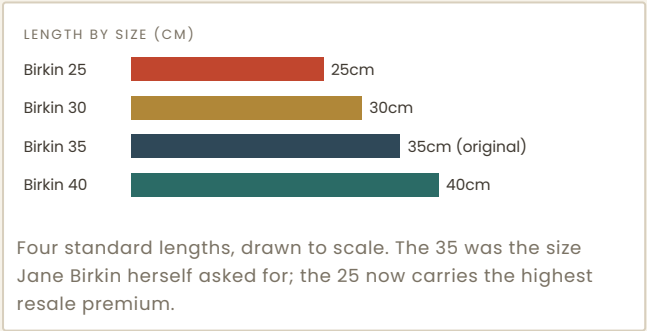
THE ARGUMENT · THE TAXONOMY

Four Sizes, Two Constructions, and a Pochette That Turns One Bag Into Three

Distinct from the Kelly's own size run — the Birkin didn't get a structured Sellier option until three decades after launch, and its taxonomy has been growing faster since.

SIZE	DIMENSIONS	READ
Birkin 25	25×20×13cm	evening/dinner; scarcest, highest premium
Birkin 30	30×22×16cm	most popular; dominant size in Asian market
Birkin 35	35×25×18cm	the original size Birkin herself requested
Birkin 40	40×30×21cm	travel/collector format, now niche

Consumer-guide consensus, not a single Hermès spec sheet — treated here as trade-standard, not primary-sourced measurement.¹ The **Sellier Birkin**, built with external, visible stitching for sharp defined edges, arrived only in 2014 — a Black 40cm in rigid, unlined Vache Hunter leather with palladium hardware — three decades after the 1984 **Retourné** original, which is stitched then turned inside-out for softer, rounded edges. Sellier construction later expanded to 25/30/35, now fully lined.²



THE RECENT VARIANTS

Birkin Faubourg (2019): a Birkin 20 in Sellier construction, built as a miniature homage to the Paris flagship at 24 Rue du Faubourg Saint-Honoré — storefront details rendered in alligator, Madame calfskin and Swift leather. A collector micro-series, not a mainline model.

Birkin Cargo (2020, revived 2024–25): a "utility luxury" canvas-and-Swift-leather piece with military-inspired pockets; a 2024 denim version drew heavy collector buzz, with new two-tone colourways in 2025.

The 3-in-1: a detachable pochette that works attached as an interior flap, removed as a standalone clutch, or recombined — "airport tote to cocktail-party clutch." Its introduction date is genuinely disputed in the record (2012 in one source, a March 2021 runway debut in another) and this book holds it as unresolved rather than print either date as fact.³

HAC (Haut à Courroies): the Birkin's acknowledged design ancestor, in Birkin-adjacent sizes from 27–60cm; a 40cm HAC runs taller than wide — the opposite of the Birkin 40's wider-than-tall proportion — with a longer strap system and different hardware.

Hardware and exotic-skin pairing carries real, if imprecisely documented, weight in Birkin-specific resale: Black Togo with either hardware finish is described as the broadest-liquidity combination, Himalaya Niloticus crocodile with palladium hardware as "the peak exotic configuration" — both dealer-guide characterisations, not audited transaction data, and printed here as such.⁴

The colourway calendar has kept moving fast enough that a book this current has to date-stamp it rather than pretend it's settled: a metallic Doré (gold) finish arrived at the end of the 2024 season, a Gris Argenté (metallic silver) followed for Spring 2025, and the 2026 palette runs to Guimauve, Crème Chantilly, Carbone, Purple, Bai Brun and Jaune Mango, alongside a seasonal "Mediterranean" set — Bleu Celeste, Jaune Soleil, Corail Pastel, Vert Menthe. Hardware finishes have widened alongside the colours: brushed gold, antique silver and dual-tone options now run beside the classic gold and palladium poles.⁵ All of this traces to dealer and resale-blog compilations of Hermès's own seasonal releases rather than a house press release this book could independently verify — real, current, but worth one more cross-check against runway or trade-press coverage before any of these names are treated as gospel.

SOURCES 1. SACLÂB, GinzaXiaoma and TheLuxuryCloset size guides, cross-checked for consistency. 2. Madison Avenue Couture and Sotheby's editorial on the 2014 Sellier Birkin introduction. 3. Rebag ("The Hermès Birkin Becomes a 3-in-1") and PurseBop's Birkin dictionary give conflicting introduction dates; genuinely unresolved in this book's research. 4. Aggregated dealer/resale-guide commentary (GinzaXiaoma, JaneFinds, Collector's Cage); not auction-house transaction data — illustrative only. 5. Madison Avenue Couture, "New Hermès 2025 Colors"; Privé Porter, "New Hermès Colors for 2026" — dealer-blog compilations, not independently verified against Hermès press materials.

THE LEDGER • PRODUCTION

Fifteen Hours a Bag, a Chairman Who Won't Cut It to Thirteen, and €769 Million Betting the Policy Holds

Hermès doesn't call it scarcity. It calls it craft time. The distinction matters less than the number both descriptions land on.

Hermès's Leather Goods & Saddlery division — the Birkin's home segment — grew revenue 17% in FY2023 to €5.55bn, 18% in FY2024 to €6.46bn (43% of group sales), and past €7bn in FY2025 (44% of group, group revenue €16bn, net profit €4.5bn).¹ That growth is not capacity-unconstrained: Axel Dumas, the executive chairman, told Business of Fashion in October 2023, "It takes 15 hours for an Hermès bag. Even if there's a lot of demand, I'm not going to start doing them in 13 hours to raise production." The same reporting states Hermès caps leather-goods volume growth at 6–7% annually by policy, preferring waiting lists to faster output, and trains roughly 400 new artisans a year — though a separate, lower-confidence figure elsewhere puts recruitment closer to 250 a year; this book could not reconcile the two and flags both.²

The house is nonetheless building: €611m went to locations, renovation and network expansion in 2024; a further €226m in 2025 specifically reinforced production capacity, within a €769m total. New leather workshops: Riom (opened September 2024, dedicated to Birkin and Constance bags), L'Isle-d'Espagnac (2025), Loupes (integrating through 2025–26), Charleville-Mézières (under construction, ~2027), and Colombelles — a 260-artisan Kelly-and-Constance facility on a former Normandy steel-mill site, announced April 2025 for a roughly 2028 opening — plus a newly announced Les Andelys site targeting 2030.³ Reported on a July 2025 earnings call, Dumas is quoted as putting the general figure at "16 hours worth of work" per bag and saying demand is such that "everything the company produces has

been sold" — this book could not independently verify the exact transcript wording and prints it as reported, not as a directly re-checked quote.

6–7%

HERMÈS'S SELF-IMPOSED ANNUAL CAP ON LEATHER-GOODS VOLUME GROWTH

€769m

2025 SPEND ON LOCATIONS, RENOVATION AND NEW PRODUCTION CAPACITY

The house's own account is that output is capped by training time, not demand suppression as a marketing choice. Analysts and critics routinely read the same 6–7% ceiling as evidence of exactly that. Both framings survive this book's checking — they simply describe the same number from opposite motives.

THE RECORD

Hermès has never published a single, official hours-per-bag figure covering the whole Birkin range — every number in circulation, this book's own included, traces to an executive's remark in a specific interview or call, not a house-issued spec. That gap is itself part of the story: a company this precise about everything else has left its most-quoted statistic to be assembled from press appearances.

SOURCES 1. Hermès FY2023 results (9 Feb 2024), FY2024 results (14 Feb 2025) and FY2025 results (12 Feb 2026), via company release coverage (leathermag.com, globenewswire.com, thefashionlaw.com, fashionunited.uk). 2. Axel Dumas, quoted in Business of Fashion, "Hermès Sales Pinched By Production Constraints," 18 Oct 2023; artisan-recruitment figures (400/yr vs. a separately-reported ~250/yr) unreconciled between sources. 3. Workshop openings/announcements per FashionNetwork (Apr 2025, Colombelles), Luxus Plus and company capex disclosures in the FY2024/FY2025 releases; exact workshop ordinal count ("24th," "27th," "28th") varies by source and is not printed here. 4. Q2 2025 earnings-call quotes via secondary transcript aggregation (Seeking Alpha/Yahoo Finance, reported ~30 Jul 2025); primary transcript not independently re-verified.

THE LEDGER • THE ANTITRUST SUIT

"Reserving the Bag for Its Highest-Paying Customers" Isn't Illegal, a Federal Judge Ruled — Twice

Two shoppers argued Hermès illegally ties Birkin access to buying other merchandise first. A federal court disagreed on the law, without ever ruling on whether the practice is true.

Cavalleri, et al. v. Hermès International, et al., filed 19 March 2024 in the US District Court for the Northern District of California, alleged Hermès sales staff are instructed to show or sell Birkins only to customers with a "sufficient purchase history" of ancillary goods — scarves, jewellery, footwear — and cited a commission structure as motive evidence: reportedly 3% commission on ancillary products, 1.5% on non-Birkin bags, 0% on Birkin sales themselves.¹ Named plaintiff Tina Cavalleri said she'd spent "tens of thousands of dollars" on Hermès goods and was told, in September 2022, the bag went to "clients who have been consistent in supporting our business"; Mark Glinoga said he was told the same across multiple attempts in 2023. The complaint alleged Hermès has sold "at least \$100 million" of Birkins annually for a decade — a figure pleaded by plaintiffs, never confirmed by Hermès, which does not break out Birkin-specific revenue anywhere in its own reporting.²

Hermès's defence, as reported from its motion-to-dismiss briefing: "The antitrust laws do not punish companies for creating better, more desirable products than anyone else." Judge James Donato dismissed the amended complaint without prejudice around 30 September 2024, finding plaintiffs failed to plausibly plead a relevant product market, Hermès's power within it, or a cognisable antitrust injury. Plaintiffs refiled with a narrower "elitist luxury handbag" market theory; Hermès moved to dismiss again — and on 17 September 2025, Donato dismissed the Sherman Act claims *with prejudice*, declining jurisdiction over the remaining state claims and closing the federal case.³

2×

DISMISSED — WITHOUT PREJUDICE (2024), THEN WITH PREJUDICE (2025)

A line attributed to Donato's September 2025 order circulates identically across multiple independent outlets — trade press and law-firm client alerts alike

— which is a reasonable signal of accuracy, though this book could not itself pull the primary docket to confirm the exact wording: "It may be, as plaintiffs suggest, that Hermes reserves the Birkin bag for its highest-paying customers, but that in itself is not an antitrust violation." Plaintiffs filed notice of appeal to the Ninth Circuit on 7 October 2025 and their opening brief on 17 February 2026; the case remains pending, with no appellate ruling reported at press time.⁴

IN BRIEF — THE CASE, DATED

19 Mar 2024: Cavalleri complaint filed, N.D. Cal.

17 Sep 2025: Sherman Act claims dismissed with prejudice.

17 Feb 2026: plaintiffs' opening appellate brief filed, 9th Circuit.

THE FILING

HERMÈS'S FRAMING

"The antitrust laws do not punish companies for creating better, more desirable products than anyone else." Plaintiffs' real complaint, in this framing, is that they can't buy a Birkin on their preferred terms — dissatisfaction, not injury.

THE FILING

THE PLAINTIFFS' FRAMING

A 0%-commission structure on the one bag everyone wants, paired with a "consistent support" requirement, isn't taste — it's a tying arrangement dressed up as relationship retailing, alleged to run to over \$1bn in Birkin sales across a decade.

THE SCEPTIC

Northeastern economist John Kwoka called the theory "probably a nonstarter on antitrust grounds" in April 2024, and the case's own outcome bore that out — but a dismissal on pleading grounds is not a finding that the underlying sales practice is fair, only that it isn't illegal under the specific doctrine plaintiffs chose. Reuters Breakingviews framed the suit, more usefully, as testing whether luxury's ordinary "fear of missing out" premium can be recast as antitrust injury — a question the ruling answers narrowly, not a verdict on Hermès's retail ethics, which [p19](#) takes up directly.

SOURCES 1. Complaint filing, N.D. Cal. Case No. 3:24-cv-01707, 19 Mar 2024, via NPR, Fortune, NBC News coverage. 2. Named-plaintiff allegations per the same coverage; sales-scale figures are plaintiff-pleaded, not Hermès-confirmed. 3. Holland & Knight client alert (Mar 2024); Zelle LLP/Law360 analysis of the Sep 2025 dismissal; Business of Fashion framing of the case's industry-wide stakes. 4. Quoted order language as reported identically across PurseBop and multiple law-firm alerts; not independently re-verified against the primary docket text in this book's research.

THE MARKET · THE INDICES

Beyond Baghunter: What the Cleaner Data Actually Says

Baghunter's reseller-funded study (p6) isn't the only index tracking handbag values. The more independent ones tell a more complicated, more recent story.

Art Market Research's Handbag Index, developed in association with the London School of Economics, is a cleaner data source than Baghunter — an independent index provider rather than a reseller marketing its own inventory, though it still licenses data from dealer and auction channels it may have commercial relationships with. Its 2020 figures showed the tracked handbag basket up 13% over twelve months, ahead of stamps (6%) and art (5%); separately, Hermès bags were reported retaining 103% of retail value on average, against Louis Vuitton's 92% and Chanel's 87%.¹ Knight Frank's Luxury Investment Index added Hermès handbags at the end of 2019, and the category promptly topped the whole index — up 13% that year, 17% in 2020. By its 2026 Wealth Report, handbags had fallen to seventh of fifteen tracked asset categories, down 0.2% across 2025: the segment's first negative year since inclusion.²

Named, dated scepticism has started catching up with the hype. Bloomberg Opinion's Allison Schrager published "Is a Birkin Bag a Good Investment? Only If You're OK With Risk" on 2 January 2026 — a mainstream financial columnist interrogating the framing directly, rather than repeating it. Fortune, in May 2025, quoted unnamed financial experts warning that treating handbags as investments "is nothing short of misleading and could be dangerous for those without proper knowledge," with the exception of "extremely rare, museum-level pieces."³ Neither piece was fully re-readable in this book's research pass — both are printed here from search-level sourcing, flagged for direct verification before any further reuse.

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HANDBAGS' 2026 RANK ON KNIGHT FRANK'S LUXURY INVESTMENT INDEX — DOWN FROM #1

-0.2%

HANDBAG SEGMENT'S 2025 RETURN — ITS FIRST NEGATIVE YEAR ON THE INDEX

COMMUNITY READ

Knight Frank's own 2026 report links the softening index to what it calls the "beater Birkin" trend — visibly worn, used-looking bags now carrying their own cachet, a shift PurseBop and others explicitly connect to Jane Birkin's own famously careless treatment of her original bag becoming an aesthetic worth imitating rather than a flaw to avoid.

Even the basic question of how many Birkins exist has no agreed answer — a genuinely striking gap for an asset class this closely tracked. One retail analyst's estimate, cited without a precisely pinned publication date, puts annual production near 70,000 bags with over a million in circulation worldwide; other, unattributed estimates put annual output closer to 12,000–15,000 — nearly a sixfold spread, with Hermès itself never having disclosed a unit-production or unit-sales figure for the Birkin in any annual report this book could locate.⁴ Every index and every resale premium discussed on this page is, in that light, tracking a market whose actual size nobody outside Hermès can state with confidence — which should temper how precisely any of these percentages get repeated.

12k–70k

THE UNRECONCILED RANGE OF ANNUAL BIRKIN PRODUCTION ESTIMATES — A ~6× SPREAD, NONE OF IT FROM HERMÈS

SOURCES 1. Art Market Research Handbag Index coverage, ~2020, via qz.com/MB Communications aggregation. 2. Knight Frank Wealth Report / Luxury Investment Index, 2020 and 2026 editions, via Douglas Elliman and PurseBop coverage. 3. Bloomberg Opinion, Allison Schrager, 2 Jan 2026; Fortune, 4 May 2025 — both sourced via search-level synthesis in this book's research; full original text not independently re-read. 4. Unattributed and analyst-estimate production figures circulating in secondary market commentary; no Hermès-disclosed figure exists to reconcile them against.

THE MARKET · THE RECORD SALE

A Ten-Minute Bidding War Over the One Birkin That Was Never for Sale

July 2025's record hammer belongs to a category of one — a sticker-covered, personally-modified prototype, not a data point for what a production Birkin is worth.

On 10 July 2025 at Sotheby's Paris, Jane Birkin's own original 1984 prototype — the actual bag Jean-Louis Dumas had built for her, not a production piece — sold after roughly ten minutes of bidding among nine collectors for a €7 million hammer (~\$8.2m), €8.6 million all-in with premium (~\$10.0–10.1m; also reported as ¥1.47bn).¹ The buyer, revealed shortly after: Valuence Japan, the Tokyo luxury-resale group led by CEO Shinsuke Sakimoto, bidding through Maiko Ichikawa, head of Sotheby's Japan. Valuence has said publicly the bag is not intended for resale, framing it instead as "cultural heritage" — it went on public display in Japan in mid-November 2025, feeding directly into the Ginza resale economy this book closes with on [p21](#).

Why it isn't a market comparable: the bag carries design features no production Birkin shares — a non-removable shoulder strap, gilded rather than gold-plated brass hardware, and dimensions between a 35 and a 40 — plus three decades of Birkin's own personal wear, stickers and modifications, the provenance that made it a piece of fashion history rather than a handbag in the ordinary resale sense. Reported as roughly double the previous handbag-auction record.²

Treat the €8.6 million sale as a provenance auction, the way the trade treats a dress worn on camera — not as evidence about what an ordinary Birkin 30 in Togo is worth this year. The two markets barely touch.

What the ordinary market actually shows, from more independent trackers, is genuinely split. Rebag's sixth annual Clair Report (December 2025) — a resale platform's own data, same conflict-of-interest caveat as Baghunter — claims Birkins appreciated 92% on resale over the past decade against a 43% Hermès retail increase, and puts Hermès's overall 2025 value retention at 138%, the highest of any tracked brand. The RealReal separately reported Birkin 30 resale values up 15% in 2025 alone.³ Bernstein Research's tracker, reported via Fortune in December 2025, tells a different story: the average Birkin/Kelly resale premium fell from 2.2× original retail in 2022 to 1.4× by November 2025 — a bag bought new for \$10,000 that would have resold near \$22,200 in 2022 now fetches closer to \$14,000. SACLÀB's Clochette Monitor, mid-2026, puts the standard Birkin Togo 30 premium at roughly 1.0× retail — essentially flat — down from 1.7× in 2022 and 1.9× in 2018.⁴

THE SCEPTIC

Every bullish figure in this section comes from a company that profits directly from bullish sentiment about Birkin resale; every bearish figure comes from an equity-research shop with no such stake. That doesn't settle which is right — Bernstein's and SACLÀB's numbers could themselves be measuring a narrower slice of the market — but a reader weighing "is this an investment" should weight the sourcing, not just the headline number.

SOURCES 1. Cross-checked across CNN, Bloomberg, France24, Japan Times, Tokyo Weekender, The Art Newspaper and Sotheby's own release, all 10 Jul 2025 or shortly after. 2. Same sourcing; prior record (2021, a diamond Himalaya bag) not independently re-confirmed in detail. 3. Rebag Clair Report, ~10 Dec 2025 (PRNewswire); The RealReal 2025 Resale Report, 4 Sep 2025 (investor.therealreal.com). 4. Bernstein Research Secondhand Pricing Tracker via Fortune (Sasha Rogelberg), 17 Dec 2025; SACLÀB Clochette Monitor, mid-2026 — SACLÀB's institutional independence not fully established in this book's research.

THE MARKET · THE CEILING, AND THE REAL EXPLANATION

What a Falling Resale Multiple Is Actually Measuring

Part of the "cooling market" story is real demand softening. Part of it is simpler: Hermès has been raising retail prices faster than resale prices are rising, which mechanically shrinks the multiple everyone quotes.

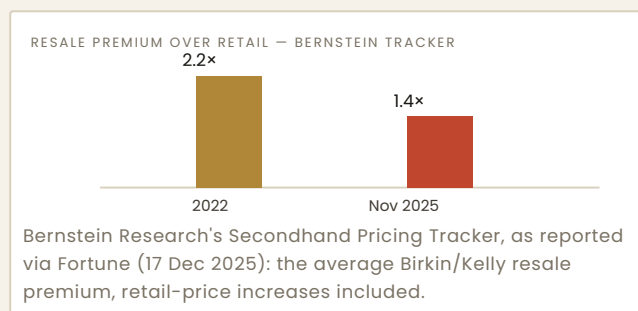
The Himalaya Niloticus crocodile Birkin — hand-painted ombré, palladium hardware, produced in tiny numbers — remains the benchmark for the production-bag ceiling. Christie's Hong Kong set a then-record \$300,168 for one in 2016; a comparable piece made \$377,000–380,000 (reports vary on exact conversion) in 2017; Heritage Auctions sold a diamond-studded example for \$250,000 in December 2024 within a \$2.58 million total sale. Sotheby's own 2024 year-end tally found six of its top ten Hermès auction results were Himalaya pieces, against two of ten in 2023 — though the single highest 2024 price, \$330,000, belonged to a Himalaya Kelly, not a Birkin, worth stating plainly rather than blurring the two.¹ A wider \$140,000–230,000 range for Himalaya Birkins circulates via one lower-authority valuation-firm blog; this book holds that range as indicative, not citable, absent a second source.

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2024'S TOP TEN HERMÈS AUCTION RESULTS WERE HIMALAYA PIECES, UP FROM 2 OF 10 IN 2023

The "is the market rising or falling" question genuinely has two honest answers depending on what's measured. Part of the fall in the quoted resale *multiple* is mechanical: Hermès has been raising Birkin retail prices aggressively — a Birkin 30 in Togo went from roughly \$11,600 in 2023 to \$12,500 in 2024, then up again 7% in the US (4.5% in Europe) in January 2025, then a further, tariff-linked 4.4–5.9% US-only rise that May — a cumulative roughly 20% US retail increase across the first five months of 2025 alone.² When the retail baseline climbs that fast, a flat or slower-rising resale price produces a shrinking "multiple over retail" even if resale demand hasn't actually weakened — a distinction most coverage citing Bernstein's 2.2×-to-1.4× figure (p11) does not make explicit.

The other part is a genuine demand story: Fortune's December 2025 framing describes 2025 as the end of a pandemic-era "luxury supercycle," citing inflation and a cooling of aspirational, Gen Z-driven resale speculation specifically — a theme this book returns to on p15.



IN BRIEF — RECONCILING THE TWO STORIES

Rising: Rebag (+92% decade), The RealReal (+15% in 2025) — both resale platforms with a direct stake.

Falling: Bernstein (2.2× → 1.4×), Knight Frank (−0.2%, 2025) — both independent of the resale trade.

Both partly right: retail prices climbing faster than resale prices is enough, on its own, to shrink the multiple everyone quotes — without any actual softening in what a used Birkin fetches in absolute terms.

One more data point, still developing as this book goes to press rather than settled: Heritage Auctions has listed a rare double-signed Birkin — a Bleu Marine Courchevel bag Jane Birkin personally inscribed twice, "Midori Your Friend Jane" — to headline its Spring 2026 luxury-accessories sale, with a pre-sale estimate of €185,000–275,000. That is an estimate, not a result, and this book will not report it as a completed sale; it's printed here only because a second Birkin carrying Jane Birkin's own handwriting, reaching auction less than a year after the €8.6 million prototype sale, is itself a small data point about how much personal provenance now moves this specific market.³

SOURCES 1. Christie's Hong Kong (2016, 2017 via SCMP/CNBC/WWD); Heritage Auctions release (Dec 2024); Sotheby's year-end editorial (2024). 2. Retail price series aggregated from Madison Avenue Couture and Privé Porter pricing-update coverage, 2023–2026; cross-checked for internal consistency across the cited increases. 3. Heritage Auctions Spring 2026 luxury-accessories sale listing; pre-sale estimate only, final result not located in this book's research.

THE FAKE · MARKET INTEGRITY

148 Bags, \$22 Million, and the Counterfeiters Were Hermès's Own Former Staff

Not a factory in another country — a ring of ex-Hermès leatherworkers, cutters and assemblers, making bags in their own homes with the skills the house itself had trained into them.

The best-documented counterfeit case directly involving Hermès isn't a customs bust — it's an inside job. Between roughly 2011 and 2014, a ring made up of former Hermès leatherworkers, cutters and assemblers produced an estimated 148 counterfeit bags, Birkins among them, made in the defendants' own homes and sold into the resale market for €23,500–32,000 each — around \$22 million in total.¹ A 2020 Paris Criminal Court trial convicted ten defendants, seven of them former Hermès staff, on counterfeiting, organised-crime and breach-of-trust charges; sentences ran from six months suspended to three years with one suspended. An appeal reportedly reached France's highest court, the Cour de cassation, which sided with Hermès — though this book could not pin the exact ruling date and holds it as reported rather than independently confirmed.²

"Superfakes" — counterfeits sophisticated enough that trade press describes "hardly any noticeable differences" to an untrained eye — are reported changing hands from roughly \$200–500 at the low end to \$6,000-plus for the most convincing examples, against genuine Birkins retailing \$12,000 to well over \$200,000.³ A 2025 wave of TikTok videos (one, from a creator identified as Wang Sen, drew 6.1 million views) claimed factories could produce a \$34,000-equivalent Birkin for as little as \$1,400, framing "over 90 percent of the retail price" as the logo alone. Forbes's April 2025 reporting pushed back directly: no contracts, shipping documents or verifiable brand relationships were ever offered, and genuine luxury contract manufacturers are almost never permitted to sell direct-to-consumer or disclose the relationship at all. Each Birkin, made by a single artisan and traceable via a

maker/workshop/year code, is structurally hard to reconcile with an anonymous factory's "direct" claim.⁴

\$22m

TOTAL SALES FROM THE 2011–14 HERMÈS-INSIDER COUNTERFEIT RING

\$467bn

OECD/EUIPO'S 2025 ESTIMATE OF GLOBAL TRADE IN FAKES — 2.3% OF WORLD TRADE

Customs data shows the scale without isolating Hermès specifically: US Customs and Border Protection seized 198 counterfeit Birkins at the Port of Savannah on 6 October 2014, MSRP estimated at \$1.86 million — the most concrete Birkin-specific seizure figure this book located, though now over a decade old. More recent CBP totals cover all counterfeit luxury, fashion and footwear together: nearly \$5 billion in FY2024, and over 78 million items with a combined MSRP above \$7.3 billion in FY2025.⁵ A separate 2025 flashpoint, culturally rather than legally significant: Walmart's own "dupe" tote, nicknamed the "Wirkin" online, intensified public debate about authenticity and resale trust across the whole category — this book found no evidence of a formal Hermès legal response to Walmart specifically, and does not print one.

THE SCEPTIC

The 2011–14 case complicates a comforting story most counterfeit coverage tells — that fakes come from criminal outsiders exploiting a brand from the shadows. Here, the skill that made the counterfeits convincing was the same skill Hermès itself had trained; the house's own craft transmission was the vulnerability, not just its trademark.

SOURCES 1. TheFashionLaw, "An Inside Job: The 2012 Counterfeit Bust That Put Hermès' Own Employees Under the Microscope." 2. South China Morning Post, "Fake Hermès Birkin bags scandal: 10 sentenced in Paris..."; TheFashionLaw follow-up on the Cour de cassation appeal, exact date not independently confirmed. 3. ABC News (undated, via search-level sourcing); cross-referenced against general Birkin retail pricing. 4. Forbes (Genna Contino), 16 Apr 2025; Taipei Times, 27 Apr 2025. 5. US CBP seizure release (Port of Savannah, 6 Oct 2014); CBP FY2024/FY2025 aggregate counterfeit-seizure figures via TheFashionLaw, "The Counterfeit Crackdown: Inside the New Border Playbook."

THE FAKE • THE ARMS RACE

Every Accuracy Number in This Fight Is Self-Reported by the Company Selling You Trust

Entrupy, Fashionphile, Rebag and Vestiaire Collective all quote confidence figures north of 90%. None of them come from an independent audit.

Four platforms now compete explicitly on authentication confidence. Entrupy, founded 2012, uses AI-driven microscopic imaging and claims 99.1% accuracy; it became an official TikTok Shop authentication partner in October 2023. Fashionphile runs Pantone colour-matching and X-ray hardware checks alongside an internal reference library — "Fashionphile University" — of Hermès stamps, fonts and date codes. Rebag's "Clair AI," launched February 2021, covers over 50 brands and roughly 15,000 recognised "Clair Codes," claiming above 90% success, though the company says two human reviewers still sign off on every item. Vestiaire Collective's first "Trust Report" (October 2022) claimed 99.9–99.93% counterfeit-detection accuracy and backs a zero-tolerance policy with a full refund if a fake slips through.¹ Every one of those percentages is self-reported by a company whose business model depends on buyers believing it — this book found no independent audit of any of the four.

Hermès has pursued counterfeiters directly and won decisively when it has: a 2012 suit against 34 "John Doe" counterfeit websites ended in an April 2012 default judgment of \$100 million in the Southern District of New York, with the infringing domains permanently transferred to Hermès.² In the NFT space, Hermès International sued artist Mason Rothschild over "MetaBirkins" digital tokens; a jury found for Hermès in February 2023, with reporting at the time putting the award near \$133,000 plus a permanent injunction against further use — a case widely covered contemporaneously, though this book's own research pass this cycle could not

independently re-pull the primary verdict record and prints the figure as it was broadly reported.³

CASE	STATUS
Hermès v. 34 counterfeit sites	\$100m judgment, 2012
Hermès "Inside Job" (staff ring)	Convicted, 2020; upheld on appeal
Hermès v. Rothschild (MetaBirkins)	Jury for Hermès, Feb 2023
Chanel v. The RealReal	Unresolved since 2018
Chanel v. WGACA	Jury for Chanel, \$4m, Feb 2023

IN BRIEF — THE GAP IN THE RECORD

Chanel has sued resale platforms directly over counterfeits — The RealReal (2018, unresolved; a related shareholder suit over its authentication disclosures separately settled, reported as either \$11m or \$11.5m depending on the outlet, a discrepancy this book could not resolve) and What Goes Around Comes Around (2018, jury verdict for Chanel, Feb 2023, \$4m statutory damages). This book found no equivalent Hermès-brought suit against a resale platform over counterfeit Birkins specifically — a real gap in the public record, not an oversight in the reporting.⁵

COMMUNITY READ

Entrupy's own 2025–26 "State of the Fake" data names Louis Vuitton as the most-counterfeited brand and breaks out a Chanel-specific scanned value near \$959 million⁴ — but no Hermès-specific fake rate appears in what this book could retrieve. Whether that's because Hermès counterfeits are genuinely rarer, or simply under-represented in the platforms' scanned volume, isn't something this book can determine from the data available.

SOURCES 1. FashionUnited (Entrupy/TikTok Shop, Oct 2023); Retail Dive (Fashionphile); PR Newswire/Forbes (Rebag Clair AI, Feb 2021); Forbes (Vestiaire Trust Report, 26 Oct 2022). 2. Olshan Law, Bloomberg (30 Apr 2012), Fashionista, JCK, Law360. 3. Hermès International v. Rothschild, SDNY, jury verdict Feb 2023, as widely and contemporaneously reported; not independently re-pulled from the primary docket in this book's current research pass. 4. WWD/Sourcing Journal, "AI Analysis Shows Global, Billion-Dollar Counterfeit Crisis," on Entrupy's 2025–26 "State of the Fake" report. 5. TheFashionLaw case-timeline coverage (Chanel v. RealReal); topclassactions.com and Sourcing Journal on the related shareholder settlement (conflicting figures); Lexology, Business of Fashion and Katten LLP (Chanel v. WGACA).

THE ROOM · THE COMMUNITY

PurseForum's Clubhouse, r/TheHermesGame, and the Voices Who Made It Public

The internet's Birkin conversation runs across a two-decade-old forum, a Reddit community roughly 73,000 strong, and a handful of accounts that built real followings just watching everyone else's bags.

PurseForum runs a dedicated Hermès sub-forum — by PurseBlog's own description one of the site's most active — plus a "Hermès Clubhouse" housing standing threads by product line. Long-running fixtures include "What was your latest Hermès purchase?" and "Riding in Cars with Bags," where members photograph their bags on car seats; a COVID-era thread, "Sheltering In Place With Hermès," ran through the pandemic. A thread titled, tellingly, "Article on Superfakes (sigh)" suggests real fatigue among members at how often the counterfeit story gets rehashed in the press.¹ This book could not retrieve the threads' actual post text and does not attribute quotes to individual members — only the threads' existence and titles, which are themselves a fair data point about what the community is actually discussing.

r/TheHermesGame on Reddit runs to roughly 73,000 members by one third-party subreddit-analytics estimate — a scraped figure, not Reddit's own live count, and printed here as approximate.² Several individuals have built real public profiles purely around watching the bag: the Instagram account @TheFakeBirkinSlayer, over 140,000 followers as of 2023 reporting, publicly flags influencers and celebrities photographed with counterfeit Birkins and Kellys; TikTok's Alex Pardoe (@BirkinTrash), around 212,000 followers, was himself publicly accused in February 2023 of attempting to resell a fake bag he said he'd been deceived into believing was genuine. London-based Israel Cassol, "Birkin Boy," roughly 183,000 followers, built the UK's largest

known male Hermès Birkin collection and uses the platform to argue for gender-neutral fashion — his collection's value is reported inconsistently between outlets (£101,000 in one, £600,000 in another, likely counting different things) and this book holds the figure rather than pick one.³

~73,000

R/THEHERMESGAME MEMBERSHIP, APPROXIMATE

COMMUNITY READ

Michael Tonello's 2008 memoir *Bringing Home the Birkin*, chronicling his years reselling Hermès via eBay, remains a genuine touchstone in collector lore — a rare case of the community's own history getting written down in a real book rather than just a forum archive.

A newer, more mainstream voice has entered the same conversation: WWD's 2026 reporting on Gen Z creators Alix Earle and Danielle Pheloung describes both actively normalising the bag for younger audiences rather than treating it as an older generation's status symbol — Earle "soft-launched" a Birkin in January with a deliberately unfiltered "what's in my bag" video drawing direct comparisons to Jane Birkin's own famously unfussy relationship with the object (p4); Pheloung posted an unboxing after securing a Paris Hermès appointment in March. WWD's own framing question — "are influencers normalising the ever-elusive, high-valued accessory?" — is the same question this book's closing pages (p16) take up directly.⁴

SOURCES 1. PurseBlog's own coverage of its PurseForum Hermès sub-forum and Clubhouse structure; thread titles confirmed via search, post content not independently retrieved. 2. gummysearch.com subreddit-analytics estimate; scrape date not established, treated as approximate. 3. About Her, Harper's Bazaar Arabia, CollectingLuxury.com (The Fake Birkin Slayer); Business Insider, Chip Chick, March 2023 (Alex Pardoe); London Post, Darling Magazine (Israel Cassol, conflicting valuation figures). 4. WWD, "Are TikTok Influencers Mainstreaming the Birkin?" — publish date given by search synthesis as ~Jun 2026, not independently confirmed via byline.

THE ROOM · OVER, OR JUST GETTING STARTED

The House's Own Chairman Says the Resale Market Is "a Real Cause for Concern." He's Also the Person Who Built It

Two arguments run in parallel through the community — that the bag is cooling among younger buyers, and that demand is now so intense Hermès's own chairman is publicly uncomfortable with it.

The "is the Birkin over" camp points to real, dated numbers: Bernstein's tracker (p11) shows the resale premium roughly halving since 2022; Fortune's December 2025 reporting frames 2025 as the end of a pandemic-era "luxury supercycle" hitting aspirational, Gen Z-driven demand specifically; and trend pieces (Storyboard18, IndexBox, Elite Traveler) argue a generation questioning "financial endurance and behavioural conformity" as the price of a status object is turning toward other signals — sneakers, running culture — instead.¹ The "Birkin is forever" camp has its own dated evidence, running in the opposite direction: WWD's 2026 reporting on Gen Z creators Alix Earle and Danielle Pheloung describes a wave of young influencers actively normalising and showcasing the bag on TikTok — not retreating from it — and July 2025's record-setting Sotheby's sale (p11) landed squarely inside this same window, not before it.

The most striking evidence that demand hasn't cooled comes from an unlikely source: the house's own chairman, complaining about it. Axel Dumas, in remarks reported around his company's mid-2025 earnings call, described "false customers" who buy Hermès's hardest-to-get bags purely to resell them, "preventing us from serving our real customers" — calling it "a real cause for concern" — and added, on the broader secondhand market for the bags themselves: "I'm not at all happy to see this development... I pull a face, and I'm not happy, and it doesn't make me feel in a good mood."² Read one way, that's a company frustrated by resale distorting its retail allocation. Read another, it's proof the demand pressure documented across this whole book (p8–9)

is real enough that even Hermès's own leadership is visibly unsettled by what it's created.

A chairman publicly unhappy about how badly people want his product is not, on its face, evidence the product is falling out of fashion.

Financial press runs both framings simultaneously, sometimes within the same publication month: Fox Business has described the bag as "a rare investment that defies depreciation," while Fortune's own May 2025 reporting — the same outlet whose December 2025 piece anchors the "cooling" case on this page — separately quoted experts warning that Gen Z buyers are being "sold a risky dream" by the investment framing itself.³ That's not a contradiction so much as two desks at the same magazine covering two different audiences: one writing for people who already own a Birkin and want reassurance, the other writing for people considering their first purchase and being warned off overconfidence.

THE SCEPTIC

These two arguments aren't actually contradictory once you separate the audiences. Aspirational, entry-level demand may genuinely be softening among younger, more price-sensitive buyers even as top-of-market, ultra-committed demand — the kind that produces "false customers" gaming the allocation system — stays as intense as ever. A single "is it over" verdict may simply be asking the wrong question of two different markets wearing the same name.

SOURCES 1. Fortune, 17 Dec 2025; Storyboard18, IndexBox and Elite Traveler Gen Z-luxury trend pieces (2025–26). 2. Axel Dumas, remarks reported around Hermès's Q2 2025 earnings period (~Jul–Aug 2025), via Men's Journal and Yahoo News secondary coverage; original transcript wording not independently re-verified. 3. Fox Business; Fortune, 4 May 2025 ("Gen Z women are being sold a risky dream...").

THE RED DOT · SINGAPORE

A S\$2.8 Billion Seizure, One Birkin Inside It, and the Collector the Tabloids Can't Stop Counting

The companion Kelly book covered Liat Towers and the general reseller scene. This is different, and specifically Singaporean: what happens to a Birkin when it turns up as evidence.

In August 2023, island-wide raids led to the arrest of ten foreigners in what became Singapore's largest-ever money-laundering case; by October that year, seized assets stood at roughly S\$2.8 billion, rising to about S\$2.79 billion by the end of 2024 after nine men and one woman were convicted and sentenced to 13–17 months for money laundering, forgery and resisting arrest.¹ In August 2025, Singapore authorities announced the liquidation of the seized luxury goods — 466 items, including Hermès and Louis Vuitton handbags, plus 58 gold bars — through Deloitte's local unit, which is to propose auction or direct-sale options to police. One outlet's synthesis of the inventory cites a Hermès Birkin 25 in Togo leather valued at S\$30,000 among the seized items, alongside a Hermès Kelly in alligator valued S\$70,000–120,000; this book could not independently confirm the Birkin figure against a second source and flags it as single-sourced.²

A separate 2025 story, thinner in the record but real: Mothership.sg reported a 20-year-old Singaporean, Malone Lam, arrested over an alleged bitcoin theft, said to have used part of the proceeds to buy Birkin bags for his girlfriend. The report exists as a single headline in this book's research — no further detail on dates, values or case status was retrievable, and it is printed here as an open thread, not a settled fact.³

S\$2.8bn

TOTAL SEIZED IN SINGAPORE'S LARGEST MONEY-LAUNDERING CASE, OCT 2023

On the other end of the ledger sits Jamie Chua — Singapore-based and widely described, including by

CNN Business in October 2025, as holding the largest known private Hermès collection anywhere, kept in a fingerprint-secured closet reported at roughly 700 square feet. Her own words to CNN: her bags "have even outperformed her financial portfolio" — a genuine, on-record instance of the "investment" framing this book interrogates elsewhere (p10), coming this time from a collector describing her own holdings rather than a study selling a thesis. One aggregator's "200-plus bags" figure for her collection could not be independently confirmed against CNN or SCMP directly and is held here rather than repeated as fact.⁴

A separate, thinner Singapore case worth naming rather than folding into the seizure above: Pi Jiapeng and his wife Pansuk Siriwiwa ran companies later accused of taking payment for luxury watches and handbags never delivered, roughly S\$32 million swindled across victims and 166 cheating charges before the couple fled the country. Reporting describes the goods only as "luxury watches and handbags" generically — this book found no confirmation the case involved Birkins specifically, and does not present it as one.⁵

THE SCEPTIC

A single collector's self-description that her bags "outperformed her financial portfolio" is not evidence for the broader investment claim this book has spent several pages complicating (p6, p10) — it's a data point of one, from someone whose entire public identity now rests on the collection being worth exactly that story.

SOURCES 1. Inquirer.net (Aug 2023); Malay Mail (3 Oct 2023); SCMP (Aug 2025, citing end-2024 totals). 2. Bloomberg (12 Aug 2025), SCMP, Business Standard, Robb Report, VnExpress International (Birkin valuation, single-sourced). 3. Mothership.sg, May 2025 — headline-level source only. 4. CNN Business, "Inside Jamie Chua's Hermès bag collection," 17 Oct 2025; "200+" bags figure per lvbagaholic.com, not independently confirmed. 5. Malay Mail, various 2022–2025 datelines, on the Pi Jiapeng/Pansuk Siriwiwa case.

THE RED DOT · THE PLATFORMS

No Singapore Auction House Has Sold a Birkin. A Singapore Rental Platform Will Lend You One Instead

The honest finding here is an absence: this book could not locate a single Sotheby's or Christie's Birkin sale staged in Singapore. What exists instead is a homegrown rental economy.

Say the gap plainly rather than stretch around it: neither Sotheby's nor Christie's has staged a Birkin-specific sale or preview in Singapore in the findable record — regional handbag auctions run through Hong Kong (Christie's has held twice-yearly accessories sales there since 2014–15) or Paris. What Singapore has built instead is a genuinely distinct model from straight resale: Style Theory, founded in Singapore by Raena Lim and Chris Halim, runs a rental-subscription platform — not ownership resale — with Singapore plans from S\$89 a month for access to more than 2,200 designer bags, Hermès among them, backed by an in-house authentication team; it expanded to Hong Kong in September 2020.¹ That's a different economic proposition from the Kelly book's consignment-and-resale coverage: renting a Birkin rather than buying one outright, at a price point that opens the object to people who would never clear the acquisition game on [p8](#).

Reebonz, also Singapore-founded (2009), is sometimes credited with authenticating "only Kelly and Birkin" among Hermès pieces — a claim traced to a single third-party guide, not Reebonz's own materials, and printed here as unverified. A Singapore-branded site, LUX.R, explicitly markets itself as a "Hermès Birkin Reseller in Singapore," though this book could confirm only its existence, not its pricing or policies. A further handful of names recur in the same aggregator's list of Singapore-active sellers of Hermès goods — Madison Avenue, HuntStreet Singapore, LuxLexicon, EcoRing, Vestiaire Collective's local presence, The Fifth Collection — none independently verified beyond that single source, and printed here as a lead list for a future issue to chase rather than as confirmed fact.²

ROUTE	MODEL
Style Theory	Rental subscription, from S\$89/mo

Reebonz	Resale; Kelly/Birkin claim unverified
LUX.R	Resale; existence-only, unverified terms
Sotheby's / Christie's	Hong Kong or Paris, not Singapore

IN BRIEF — BRINGING ONE HOME

Singapore's GST import relief runs S\$500 for trips of 48 hours or more, S\$100 for shorter stays; above that, GST applies at 9% of the item's CIF value, declarable via the Customs@SG app or the Red Channel on arrival — official, current guidance from Singapore Customs and IRAS, and the one part of this section with no sourcing caveat attached.³

On a S\$13,500 Birkin 25 ([p7](#)), that 9% GST alone runs to roughly S\$1,215 above the S\$500 relief threshold — worth budgeting for before the boutique appointment, not after.

COMMUNITY READ

Targeted searches of HardwareZone's EDMW forum and r/singapore for Birkin-specific threads turned up nothing citable — mostly unrelated marketplace listings. This book states that plainly rather than manufacture a local forum sentiment that, on the evidence available, doesn't clearly exist in the way it does for Kelly's Liat Towers coverage.

Set against Hong Kong's genuine handbag-auction infrastructure ([p12](#)) or Japan's decades-deep resale economy ([p21](#)), Singapore's Birkin footprint reads less like an absence and more like a different kind of market entirely — one built on rental subscriptions, quiet consignment listings and, on the evidence of this chapter's own opening page, the occasional police inventory, rather than a saleroom podium. That's a genuinely distinct Singapore story from the Kelly book's Liat Towers coverage, even if it's a thinner one; this book would rather report the thinner true story than borrow the thicker one from a neighbouring bag.

SOURCES 1. Inside Retail (9 Sep 2020); Retail News Asia; Style Theory's own pricing pages. 2. fromhktosg.github.io aggregator (Reebonz claim, unverified); lux-r.com.sg (existence confirmed, content not independently fetched). 3. Singapore Customs and IRAS official guidance; Wise's 2026 consumer guide, cross-checked against the government sources.

THE SCEPTIC · THE FRAMING

Every Argument in This Book Has, at Some Point, Treated a Handbag Like an Asset Class

This desk doesn't introduce new material — it cross-examines what the previous sixteen pages already established, and asks what it adds up to.

Run this book's own pages back and the pattern is hard to miss. A reseller-funded study claims 14.2% annual returns (p6). Auction houses market a bag genealogy partly to sell collectors on provenance (p4). Three separate indices disagree with each other about whether the asset is appreciating (p10). A federal lawsuit argued, unsuccessfully, that access to the object itself should be treated as an antitrust question (p9). None of that is how anyone talks about a handbag. It's how people talk about a security. Bloomberg Opinion's Allison Schrager put the sceptical version of this plainly in January 2026: a Birkin might be a good investment, "only if you're okay with risk" — the same caveat that applies to any illiquid, sentiment-driven asset, dressed up in leather rather than a prospectus.¹

Reuters Breakingviews framed the underlying mechanism, in its coverage of the Cavalleri suit (p9), as luxury's ordinary "fear of missing out" premium — the thing that makes any scarce, aspirational object desirable — being tested as a legal theory rather than a marketing fact. The court declined to treat FOMO as antitrust injury. It did not, and could not, rule on whether FOMO is a rational basis for a five- or six-figure purchase, which is a different question entirely, and the one this desk actually asks.

A federal judge ruling that reserving a bag for your highest-paying customers isn't illegal is not the same as a financial adviser ruling that buying one is wise.

2

INDEPENDENT, NON-COMMERCIAL TRACKERS (BERNSTEIN, KNIGHT FRANK) NOW SHOW THE RESALE PREMIUM FALLING²

IN BRIEF — SORTING THE SOURCES BY INTEREST, NOT BY HEADLINE

Has a stake in "it's a great investment": Baghunter, Rebag, The RealReal, Fashionphile, auction houses marketing provenance.

Has no obvious stake either way: Bernstein Research, Knight Frank, Bloomberg Opinion, the Northeastern and Reuters legal commentary.

The pattern: nearly every bullish figure in this book traces to the first group; nearly every note of caution traces to the second. That alone should recalibrate how much weight a reader gives the "better than gold" claim on sight.

THE SCEPTIC

Strip out every source in this book with a direct commercial interest in the bullish case — the resellers, the platforms, the auction houses — and what's left is thinner and more mixed than the popular "better than gold" claim suggests: a genuinely one-of-a-kind provenance sale, a falling resale multiple by the more independent measures, and a chairman publicly unhappy about the very demand his own scarcity strategy created.

SOURCES 1. Bloomberg Opinion, Allison Schrager, 2 Jan 2026, as summarised via search-level sourcing (full text not independently re-read); Reuters Breakingviews, "Hermès lawsuit attacks luxury's FOMO premium," 28 Mar 2024. 2. Bernstein Research Secondhand Pricing Tracker via Fortune, 17 Dec 2025 (see p11); Knight Frank Wealth Report / Luxury Investment Index, 2026 edition (see p10).

THE SCEPTIC · THE ETHICS

Deliberate Scarcity Is a Legitimate Business Strategy. It Is Also, on Its Own Terms, an Uncomfortable One

Neither the sourcing question nor the scarcity question has a clean answer this book can hand the reader — only the honest shape of the argument on both sides.

The exotic-skin question is the one this book found collectors and critics raising loudest against themselves, not just against Hermès. Jane Birkin's own 2015 request to remove her name from the crocodile Birkin (p4) came after PETA's undercover footage of improper slaughter practices at a Texas farm — and the request, notably, was never actually granted; the bag still carries her name in 2026. That leaves every collector who buys a crocodile or alligator Birkin holding an object whose most famous namesake publicly objected to how the material was sourced, and whose objection the house did not act on in the way she asked. This book takes no position on whether that makes the purchase unethical — only that a collector who hasn't weighed it hasn't fully reckoned with the object.¹

The "artificial scarcity" question is closer to a genuine business-ethics debate than a scandal. Axel Dumas's own framing — that Hermès won't compress fifteen hours of craft into thirteen to raise output (p8) — is a coherent, defensible account of why the waiting list exists. It is also, functionally, indistinguishable from a company that has discovered scarcity sells better than abundance and built a production policy around that discovery, whichever motive is the true one. This book could not find a documented instance of Hermès executives being pressed on this specific tension at a shareholder AGM — only the earnings-call and press remarks already quoted across this book, which speak to the same discomfort without ever fully resolving it.²

11 yrs

SINCE BIRKIN'S 2015 CROCODILE REQUEST — STILL NOT
ACTED ON AS SHE ASKED

IN BRIEF — WHAT THIS BOOK WILL AND WON'T CONCLUDE

Will conclude: the "better than gold" claim is weaker, and more commercially interested, than its ubiquity suggests.

Will conclude: the exotic-skin sourcing question remains genuinely open, on the house's own namesake's terms.

Won't conclude: whether owning a Birkin at all is defensible. That's the reader's call, not this book's.

Zoom out one level and the two ethics questions on this page turn out to share a structure. Both ask whether a company can be held responsible for the gap between what it publicly says and what a sceptical reading of its own actions suggests. On sourcing: Hermès said it shared Birkin's concerns, audited, and reported an "isolated irregularity" — language that resolves the news cycle without resolving whether the underlying practice actually changed to her stated satisfaction. On scarcity: Hermès says fifteen hours of craft, not a marketing choice — language that is entirely plausible on its own terms and impossible to fully separate from a company that has also discovered scarcity sells. Neither gap proves bad faith. Both are exactly the kind of claim this book's honesty law exists to flag rather than either accept or reject on the company's word alone.

COMMUNITY READ

The collector forums this book surveyed (p15) argue fiercely about condition, hardware and resale timing. They argue far less, on the evidence this book could gather, about the sourcing and scarcity questions raised here — which may say as much about what collector communities are built to discuss as it does about whether those questions matter to the people asking them.

SOURCES 1. See p4 sourcing on the 2015 PETA investigation and Birkin's AFP statement. 2. See p8 sourcing on Axel Dumas's production-capacity remarks; no AGM-specific exchange located in this book's research.

THE UNDERCURRENT · GINZA

Why Japan Has Been Quietly Selling the World's Secondhand Birkins for Thirty Years

A decades-old habit of careful ownership, a licensing regime that keeps buyers trusting resale, and now a weak yen pulling the whole world's attention back to Tokyo at once.

Komehyo Holdings, founded in Nagoya in 1947 and listed on the Tokyo Stock Exchange, describes itself as Japan's largest reuse department store — its Shinjuku flagship runs eight floors and over 2,000 items across bags, jewellery and watches, with a second flagship in Ginza and dedicated kaitori (buy-back) centres as far as Kobe and Osaka. One current listing quotes a reference buy-back price of ¥2,650,000 for a Birkin 25 in Togo leather, K-stamp, graded "Used Grade A" — a single snapshot, not a published formula, since none of Japan's major players appear to publish an actual Birkin price index.¹ Brand Off runs a Ginza store reportedly devoting its entire third floor to Hermès, plus an active international eBay storefront. And Valuence Holdings — parent of the buy-back brand Nanboya and the international "ALLU" resale chain, led by former professional footballer turned CEO Shinsuke Sakimoto — is the same company that bought Jane Birkin's own original prototype bag at Sotheby's Paris for €8.6 million in July 2025 (p11), stating publicly it would not be resold.²

Why Japan specifically: the most consistent explanation across the trade and travel press this book surveyed is a habit that goes back to the 1980s asset-bubble years, when an enormous nationwide accumulation of European luxury goods entered Japanese households and never fully left circulation — feeding secondhand supply for three-plus decades since. That causal story is repeated widely across blog-level sourcing rather than a single economic-history source this book could verify start to finish, and is printed with that caveat.³ More solidly corroborated: a cultural norm, described consistently

across many independent sources, of using luxury bags sparingly, storing them carefully with original boxes and receipts, and treating resale as a normal, low-stigma transaction rather than a distress sale — underpinned by Japan's secondhand-dealer licensing regime, administered through prefectural police, which gives buyers real confidence in a market's legitimacy.

¥2.65m

KOMEHYO'S CURRENT BUY-BACK REFERENCE PRICE FOR ONE BIRKIN 25 CONFIGURATION

COMMUNITY READ

Weak-yen tourism has layered onto that base directly: preowned Hermès in Tokyo is reported running 10–30% below US and European prices even before tax-free savings, pulling foreign buyers — Chinese tourists named repeatedly in the coverage — toward both new and secondhand purchases in the same trip.

Komehyo's own condition-grading language — "Used Grade A," "Used Grade B," "Unused" — sits inside a wider industry convention one secondary source describes running S (like-new) through C or D (visible wear, disclosed defects); the same source claims Komehyo's authenticators train for months before being cleared to grade high-value pieces. This book could not confirm either detail beyond that single blog and prints both as reported, not verified.⁴ What is independently confirmable: Komehyo runs dedicated kaitori (buy-back) centres beyond Tokyo, in Kobe Sannomiya and Osaka Umeda — the infrastructure is national, not a Tokyo curiosity, a point worth making before this chapter narrows to Ginza specifically on the next page.

SOURCES 1. Komehyo Holdings company profile (PitchBook, TipRanks); komehyo.jp product listings. 2. BagUSeek Tokyo shopping guides (Brand Off); Valuence/ALLU company materials, The Value/ArtNews on Shinsuke Sakimoto. 3. Blog-level trade/travel sourcing (multiple independent outlets converge on the theme; no single economic-history source independently verified in full). 4. findluxuryjapan.com — single unverified blog source, printed with that caveat.

THE UNDERCURRENT · THE HONEST GAP

No Native-Language Voice Made It Into This Chapter. Say So, Rather Than Fake One

Every source in this section is English-language reporting about Japan's resale culture — genuinely convergent, but never a Japanese collector's own words.

Ginza's geography is real and specific: Brand Off's Hermès floor and Ginza Celia and Orange Boutique — the last stocking over 600 Hermès items a minute's walk from Ginza Station — sit within the same compact district as Hermès's own Maison flagship, deliberately presented, per multiple accounts, with boutique-grade polish rather than pawnshop styling. Beyond Tokyo, Mercari and Yahoo! Auctions carry the bulk of Japan's consumer-to-consumer Hermès trade, reached internationally almost entirely through proxy-shopping services — Buyee, FromJapan, ZenLuxe — since neither platform ships abroad directly.¹ A regulatory peg worth flagging forward: Japan's inbound tax-free shopping system is set to shift from point-of-sale exemption to a refund-based model from 1 November 2026, a genuine, dateable change to exactly the economics this chapter describes.

This book's honesty law requires saying plainly what it could not do here: no Japanese-language forum, blog or collector voice was directly reached in this research pass, and no published Birkin-specific Japanese price index was located from any of the three named players — Komehyo, Brand Off and Valuence all appear to price bag by bag, after physical inspection, rather than publish a running index the way Bernstein or SACLÀB do for the Western resale market (p11). What's printed above is consistent, convergent English-language reporting about the Japanese market — real, and worth trusting as far as it goes — but it is reporting *about* Japanese collectors, never their own words. A book that has spent twenty pages insisting on primary sourcing over secondary retelling (p3) owes the reader that same standard applied to itself.²

The gap is worth naming precisely rather than gesturing at: a fuller version of this chapter would read Yahoo! Auctions Japan's own completed-listing data for Birkin lots directly, would follow a Japanese-language Mercari search through actual asking and

closing prices, and would quote a Ginza shop's own staff on what a Birkin 25 in good condition genuinely moves for on a Tuesday rather than what an English-language blog claims it does. None of that happened in this research pass, for the reasons stated above. This book would rather hand the reader that precise a to-do list than paper over the gap with confident-sounding prose.

The most honest sentence in this chapter may be the one admitting what it couldn't reach, not the one describing what it could.

Bloomberg's own November 2025 follow-up to the July prototype sale profiles one working example of the trade this chapter describes: a dealer identified as Kris Jiang, 29, reported on track to make \$1.6 million this year reselling luxury bags "mostly sourced from Japan" — a single, named individual's business, not a market-wide statistic, but a concrete illustration of the arbitrage this chapter has otherwise described only in aggregate.³ Multiply that one dealer's volume by however many similar operators the proxy-shopping ecosystem supports — Buyee, FromJapan and ZenLuxe all explicitly list Hermès and Birkin as specialty categories — and the shape of the trade becomes clearer even without a total figure this book could verify.

\$1.6m

ONE JAPAN-SOURCING DEALER'S REPORTED 2025 RESALE VOLUME — A SINGLE CASE, NOT A MARKET TOTAL

THE SCEPTIC

Bloomberg's November 2025 framing — that the July 2025 record sale is itself boosting Japan's vintage-luxury trade, illustrated by that one dealer's \$1.6 million — is a single anecdote about one individual, not a market-wide statistic. It's suggestive of momentum. It isn't proof of it.

SOURCES 1. BagUSeek, Weekly Lux Drop and Emily in Tokyo Tokyo-shopping guides; Japan Dev and ipfoxy on Mercari/Yahoo Auctions; ginzacelia.com and japantravel.com on the Nov 2026 tax-free system change. 2. This book's own research-pass limitations, stated directly. 3. Bloomberg, 21 Nov 2025, on Kris Jiang and Japan-sourced luxury resale; via search-level sourcing, full text not independently re-read.

THE UNDERCURRENT · THE ARGUMENT

Twenty Pages of Scarcity, Ending in the Country That Turned It Into Supply

Every desk in this book has priced, in its own way, the gap between what the Birkin promises and what the market actually delivers. Japan's resale economy is the one place that gap gets closed rather than argued over.

Run this book back to front and one thread connects every desk: an object whose own founding date its most famous namesake couldn't fix across three decades of retelling (p3), whose production hours the house has confirmed only in scattered interview remarks (p8), whose allocation logic a federal court ruled isn't illegal even if entirely real (p9), and whose investment case rests on a reseller's own decade-old arithmetic more than on independent data (p6, p10) — all of it held together by scarcity Hermès manufactures with genuine skill and defends in public with genuine discomfort (p16). Japan's secondhand economy is the first response this book encountered anywhere in its research that doesn't argue with that scarcity. It simply recirculates around it, at scale, for profit, without any of the moral weight the rest of this book's sources keep attaching to the chase.

That's a genuinely different move from either side of the debate documented elsewhere in this book. It isn't the quota-chaser's strategy (p8–9), spending years building the relationship a Birkin allocation reportedly requires. It isn't the counterfeiter's strategy either (p13–14), which depends on a fake being mistaken for genuine. Komehyo's buy-back price, Valuence's headline-making auction win, Brand Off's whole Hermès floor — none of it pretends the bag isn't scarce, or fakes what it isn't. It simply treats a forty-year-old stockpile as inventory, and lets the weak yen do the rest.

Hermès spent four decades building an object desirable enough that an entire country's secondhand economy could run substantially on nothing but recirculating what it already bought in the 1980s. That is either the scarcity strategy working exactly as designed, or the clearest evidence that the object always mattered more than the story Hermès tells about it — and this book, honestly, cannot fully tell which.

Whether Japan's resale boom outlasts the current weak-yen cycle, or the record-setting July 2025 sale marks a genuine high-water mark rather than a new normal, is not something this book can predict and will not pretend to. What it can say, on the evidence gathered across every desk in this special edition: an object this carefully rationed, this expensively made, this opaquely allocated, still ends up — a decade or three later, one careful Japanese owner at a time — simply for sale. That is either the most ordinary thing in the world for a well-made handbag to become, or the quietest possible rebuttal to everything the rest of this book has argued about scarcity. This book leaves the verdict to the collector it was built for.

THE SCEPTIC

A resale economy this large is not, on its own, proof that the scarcity strategy has failed — Hermès may be entirely comfortable with a secondary market that keeps the object desirable without diluting what a NEW Birkin costs to acquire. This book's closing argument is the narrower, more defensible one: Japan's resale economy is real, current and well documented, not that it undermines the house's own business model.

THE LAST WORD

This book was built to sit alongside No. 75.5's Kelly special without repeating a page of it — same collector-level standard, same instruction underneath every section: get it right, or say plainly it couldn't be pinned down. That cost this book some of its most-repeated claims — a flight date Jane Birkin herself couldn't hold steady across three decades, a design lineage that turns out to be auction-house marketing more than Hermès history, a "better than gold" statistic that traces to one reseller's own arithmetic. It gained, in their place, an honest reckoning most Birkin writing never bothers to attempt — and a closing chapter this book did not expect going in: a country that answered forty years of engineered scarcity not by chasing it or resenting it, but by quietly reselling it back to the world, one careful owner at a time. Whether that is the scarcity strategy's triumph or its clearest rebuttal is a question this book raises rather than answers — the plainest place its honesty law could land.

FULL SOURCE LIST

Sotheby's editorial & press releases · Christie's · Vogue (Luke Leitch, Mar 2012) · CNN / CNN Business / CNN Opinion · Bloomberg & Bloomberg Opinion (Allison Schrager) · Reuters Breakingviews · Fortune (Sasha Rogelberg) · Business of Fashion · The Fashion Law · Forbes · Smithsonian Magazine · TIME · Euronews · France24 · Japan Times · Tokyo Weekender · The Art Newspaper · WWD · Sourcing Journal · South China Morning Post · Malay Mail · Business Standard · Robb Report · VnExpress International · Mothership.sg · Inquirer.net · PurseBlog / PurseForum · PurseBop · Madison Avenue Couture · Privé Porter · Xupes · JaneFinds · SACLÀB · Rebag (Clair

Report) · The RealReal · Bernstein Research (via Fortune) · Knight Frank (Wealth Report / KFLII) · Art Market Research · Baghunter · Style Theory · Reebonz · Komehyo Holdings · Brand Off · Valence Holdings / ALLU · Entrupy · Fashionphile · Vestiaire Collective · OECD/EUIPO ("Mapping Global Trade in Fakes 2025") · Holland & Knight · Zelle LLP / Law360 · Northeastern University (John Kwoka) · CBS "60 Minutes" · Singapore Customs · IRAS · gummysearch.com · Their Turn · CBS News · AFP · Storyboard18 · IndexBox · Elite Traveler · Heritage Auctions · BagUSeek · Weekly Lux Drop · Emily in Tokyo · ginzacelia.com · japantravel.com.